

WAR IS HELL!

You're in the Army now: Playing World War II shooters was never this much fun!

To be honest, I wasn't very excited about being assigned this game to review. I'm not the type who likes WW II shooters! I opened the impressive-looking packaging and pulled out the game box, only to scream in dismay when I saw there were six CDs! "That's 14 times I need to open/close my optical drive!", I moaned—after installing the sixth CD it asks for CD 1 again. Seriously, a DVD would have been nice. (Note to self: please inform all game companies to only send DVDs for review!) I used an AMD Athlon64 3200+, 1 GB DDR 400 MHz RAM, a GeForce 6600 256 MB card and an 80 GB SATA hard drive, and it still took ages to install. "This better be a good game," I muttered.

To my surprise, I started off as a Russian in the game—now that was new to me. The AI is so good that even at the normal difficulty level, the game requires a very different approach from most of the other first person shooters. If you run around trying to blow people away, be prepared to start from the last save point a few hundred times! The enemy AI is good, and depicts the actions of humans well: most FPS games have monsters that charge at you like there's no tomorrow; in *Call Of Duty 2* (COD2), enemy (German) snipers will try and blow you to kingdom come from within hiding, and most foot soldiers prefer to hurl grenades rather than try and move up to attack you! Basically, the AI knows how to protect itself, and killing your enemies is not as easy as point and shoot.

Despite not having played the original game, it took me just five minutes to get used to the nuances of this series: every now and then I'd just fall flat on my face, deadier than a doornail, wondering what hit me—then I saw the grenade alert indicator! Overall, the learning curve is pretty flat.

I'd turned up the visual detail to maximum in order to enjoy the game to its fullest, but found that it can get a little sluggish and start framing on my configuration. A resolution of 1024 x 768, with 4x AA, trilinear filtering, and with everything else left to the default seemed to work—so that's what I used.

The Missions

Like I mentioned earlier, I started off with team mates who said "Come on comrade, kill the Nazis," then came team mates who said "A'ight mate, let's send these Nazi blokes back to Berlin," to becoming a US corporal... well, you get the drift. Whether as a Russian, British or US soldier, I sure did kill a lot of Nazis. Which made me scratch my head and think, "Does anyone in Germany actually buy this game?"

The missions take you through the streets of Stalingrad, fighting off hordes of attacking Germans, on to the African Sahara, grinding the Desert Fox's (Field Marshall Rommel's) armoured forces into the dust, and finally on to the American attack of Europe. During the 10 missions, you crawl through pipes to get behind enemy lines, drive a tank and destroy some Panzers, and finally hold out on European soil till your reinforcements arrive.



1
Apart from shooting, you have simple tasks to complete...



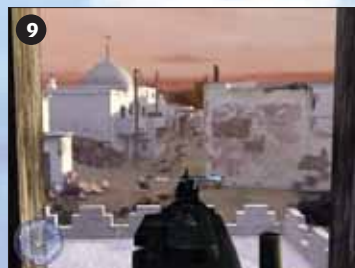
2
...like blowing up this building with the explosives you planted earlier



5
Each new campaign starts with some authentic WW II TV footage



6
At some points, AI is stupid: they just kept coming down in a line and dying!



9
Then at dawn you have Germans attacking like Japanese Kamikazes



10
Then you defend a British base from marauding Germans in the desert



13
My first landing on a beach and I'm promptly knocked out by a shell!



14
Now that's a bug: a dead Jerry doing a balancing act on a cliff!



17
Friends or foes, they're all dead—war really is hell!



18
Here comes the cavalry: the USAF saves my miserable behind again!